

well as a wide variety of short-term training courses in GIS software. The qualifications and training required depends largely on the area you want to work in—application development, analysis, data conversion, etc.

Courses offered by most software training institutes concentrate more on training in GIS software, rather than on the applications of GIS. However, some institutes do offer training in the applications of GIS technology. If you're serious about a career in data analysis then you should consider a formal degree or a post-graduation in earth sciences from a reputed institute. (See box on GIS training courses)

The buzz about GIS

GIS has been used in India since the mid 1960s primarily by government and research sectors in areas such as natural resource management and environmental planning, urban planning, transportation and civil engineering. With data represented graphically in the form of maps acquiring importance in many industries as a decision making tool, GIS technology is finding wider acceptability in many industries—health, business management (where it is used to map existing and potential clients), assigning sales territories, distribution facilities and so on. And here's the bright side. "The global market for GIS has been estimated at over \$7 billion and the domestic

market in India itself is worth over Rs 750 crore," says Prasad. But there is a shortage of skilled technical manpower to execute GIS projects.

Thakur says, "Around 30 to 40 per cent of the domestic GIS market is concentrated on the sale of software, applications and hardware and approximately 70 per cent of the business comes from providing services." He adds that most of the GIS services in India cater to the overseas market, particularly the US. "There's very little work being done for the Indian market and most of the GIS projects are commissioned by the government sector." Prasad, however, estimates that in India alone over Rs 6,000 crore will be spent on GIS in the next five to seven years. He says, "Municipal planning, forestry and environment, telecommunications and rural land records are the areas wherein the action is already on." The GIS project for Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board, GPS based transport system for Banaglore, Early Warning System for crop monitoring by the Ministry for Agriculture, Disaster Management for Delhi are some of the examples of projects carried out in India. Thakur feels that areas such as location-based services, remote sensing and photogrametry are areas in which demand will outstrip supply and Prasad agrees with this. So what's holding you back? Get set to ride the GIS wave! 

<http://www.wv>

www.gisdevelopment.net
For more information on
GIS in South Asia

www.csdms.org
Centre for Spatial Database
Management and Solution

www.geocomm.com
A portal on GIS

www.gisafe.com
Information on job oppor-
tunities in this field

www.esri.com
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